Salted Laurel

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Salted Laurel

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Mydei receives a sacred heirloom thought lost to gods and time. He deduces the culprit with the skill of a war tactician and the patience of a wronged lover. Phainon, meanwhile, is dragged mid-day across Okhema like a sack of honor. A laurel is offered. A hand is kissed. Dignity is not spared. Kremnos: 1. Okhema: emotionally concussed.

Notes

4k I said…

Also guys we got fanart YIPPYYY! Check this link out, THIS ONE TOO!!!

See the end of the work for more notes

The sun never set in Okhema.

Under Kephale’s light, the sky remained pale and gold-stained, as though scorched into place. It filtered through latticework and ivory screens, so that even the night hours glowed like the inside of a closed eye. In this strange city—built on hymns and democracy, where debates outlasted wars and men adorned themselves with silvered tongues—Mydei had learned to keep his silence as one keeps a weapon: sheathed, but near the heart.

Tonight, the lamps in his chambers flickered with oil-slick quiet. They did not offer heat. Only the impression of watching.

Mydei sat cross-legged at the low writing table, the parchment before him bordered in gold leaf and official insignia. The letter he had begun was addressed to no one. Meant for no one. It was practice, perhaps. A Kremnoan discipline. His calligraphy was precise, square-jawed and unbending, the script of formal edicts and funeral oaths. He wrote slowly, not from uncertainty, but with the gravity of someone who believed the shape of words could call storms or still them.

The letter would never be sent. He had known that before the first word met the ink.

There were things in Okhema he did not understand. That, in itself, was tolerable. Kremnos taught that a man who understood everything had no need of courage.

But this—this was different.

The fourth gift had arrived this morning.

Like the others, it had come without note or herald. Left not at his door, but somehow within the room itself—placed with unnerving precision. The kind of presence that felt like absence, so carefully was it done. Not grand, not lavish. But exact. Chosen. As if the sender had reached deep enough into his bones to know what still lived there.

The first time, he had tried to ignore it. The second, he had set it aside with the air of a man tolerating something he would one day strike down. By the third, he’d begun to frown—not in disapproval, but thought.

And now, with the fourth—he was writing.

Not to the sender. That would have implied acknowledgment.

But his hand, traitorous thing that it was, had moved to ink before he could stop it. His words did not confess, or invite. They asked nothing. Instead, they traced the outline of the space this presence had carved into his days, in the quiet between drills and formal assemblies.

He had not told anyone.

Not the attendants. Not the council aides who lingered like birds along the eaves of governance. Certainly not Phainon, who had passed him earlier today with the kind of glance that might’ve been politeness. Or something else.

He had not told anyone because there was nothing to tell. These were not courtly gestures. Not flirtations wrapped in ribbon and flattery.

They were stranger than that. Sharper.

There is no honor in wondering. Only weakness, as the old Kremnoan proverb went.

And yet.

He wondered.

Not constantly. Not like the young ones who wrote poems on their knees and looked for signs in tea leaves and candle smoke.

But in the moments when he found himself setting things aside to make room on his shelf. Or when his hand moved too quickly toward a sound by the window, only to still again. Or when he wrote letters meant for no one.

He did not smile when the thought came.

He only acknowledged it, as one might acknowledge the presence of a worthy adversary on a battlefield.

It seems I have gained an admirer, he thought.

Not with fondness.

With cool, precise curiosity.

As if assessing the trajectory of an arrow mid-flight.

It had started a few weeks prior.

He remembered the moment not because of any flourish or spectacle, but because it came with the same quiet finality as a drawn blade.

The gift was a jar of honey.

Thick, amber, and sealed in dark ceramic. He had recognized the shape of the jar before he saw the crest pressed faintly into its waxed lid. *Meli tou Lithou.* Honey of the Stone. Harvested from the cliffs below Mount Edrasos, where the bees fed on ironroot and bitter wild fig. It was a rare thing—scarce even in Kremnos. Most only tasted it during winter ceremonies, or when a warrior fell far from home and needed to be remembered.

The name sounded poetic to foreign ears. But in Kremnoan, its meaning was blunt: Even the mountains bleed honey, if you cut deep enough.

He had not touched it at first.

Instead, he had stood with it in his hands, weight steady as if gauging whether it was trap or tribute. The sun in Okhema never truly set—its light, softened by Kephale's strange mercy, pooled through the high windows in muted gold. But the scent struck him like a thing unsheathed.

It smelled of dry summers and sharp rocks. Of bronze under the sun. Of the tongue his mother had used before she bled out and died a death worthy of her line.

He had been too young to hold the blade then. But he remembered the word she used when she looked up at him.

Live.

It was not a plea. It was an order.

Now, years later, that same dialect—the one no one spoke here—curled from the jar like smoke rising off memory.

In Okhema, language was delicate. Draped in preambles and softened corners. One could debate a man's honor without ever raising the voice. Their greetings were long, their farewells longer. A single Kremnoan sentence, by comparison, could level a room.

A salt-haired soldier once said it best over charred meat and fire: *"We do not eat honey for sweetness. We eat it to remember hunger."*

And this—this gift—it remembered.

That unsettled him more than he cared to admit.

No signature. No inked token of affection. No attempt to explain itself. It did not ask to be liked. It was not a question.

It was a statement.

Mydei had kept it, saying nothing. The attendants had not commented, though he caught one glancing at it later with a look too careful to be idle.

That night, after council, he tore flatbread in half with a warrior's neat efficiency and spooned the honey across its surface. He ate in silence, back straight, posture unchanged. No indulgence showed in his face.

But when he washed his hands, he did so more slowly than usual.

As if he might still feel some trace of it clinging to the skin.

He kept the jar.

Not for sentiment. But—for evidence.

He did not keep many things.

The dagger from his first campaign.

The cloth from the duel's end, torn from Phainon's sleeve when they had collapsed, breathless and bloodied, in the dust.

Now this.

Honey.

The ceremony had begun an hour ago, though no one could say when exactly the speeches started. They wove in and out of each other like smoke, the way Okhemians preferred: with soft edges and beautiful digressions, phrases curled like incense over altar flames.

Mydei stood among the row of honored dignitaries, draped in Kremnoan red and steel-threaded gold. He bore no sigils, no medals. His presence was his rank. And his silence, his command.

He endured it like a siege.

In Kremnos, if a man spoke for more than five minutes, it was because he was dying or declaring war. Here, in the holy city of Okhema, men debated each other for sport. They praised one another with such exquisite subtlety that the insults could take hours to land.

They waste breath like it is an inexhaustible thing.

The councilor beside him had spoken for fourteen minutes and counting. The man's robes were delicate and embroidered with sea-glass. Mydei had once cut through chainmail with less effort.

And still he stood. Unmoving. His face carved from the same stone that had once birthed Meli tou Lithou.

A new speaker took the dais, more silver-tongued than the last, and Mydei's gaze drifted—just slightly—across the hall. He did not seek anyone in particular. But he found Phainon.

The Deliverer of Amphoreus stood half in shadow, flanked by sun-painted columns, his ceremonial whites catching the pale gold light in a way that made him look lit from within. He wore command as easily as a second skin, and even here, even now, managed to seem both approachable and eternal.

Mydei did not flinch under the glance they exchanged. A formal nod. That was all.

But when Phainon moved through the aisle moments later, passing just close enough to draw in a breath of him—salt, citrus, something sun-warmed—he spoke without pause in the low, easy register of a man who had never once needed to raise his voice to be obeyed.

"You look like you'd rather be sparring ghosts than sitting here."

Mydei did not glance over. His own reply was smooth, cold-edged.

"If you find me a ghost worth the steel, I'll consider it."

That earned him a quiet huff of breath. Not quite a laugh. But not displeased, either.

Phainon drifted forward, absorbed again into the ceremonial tide.

Their words had been brief. Perfectly formal.

And yet, not quite.

Mydei had not hated it.

He had not hated *him*.

This man had once crossed blades with him for ten nights and days beneath a burning sky. And neither of them had yielded.

Phainon had earned his name in that ring. Had earned something more valuable than Mydei's regard.

He had earned, if not allegiance, then the rarest of Kremnoan acknowledgments:

This one, I would trust at my back.

After Phainon passed, Mydei did not turn to watch him go. Not immediately. That would have suggested interest.

But later, when the ceremony dipped into yet another invocation of unity and progress, he let his gaze drift again—like a man assessing the walls of a fortress he did not plan to storm but wanted to know well.

Phainon stood across the hall, now half-turned in polite conversation with a delegation from the southern coasts. He laughed once—shoulders easy, expression bright—and for a moment, he looked precisely as he was meant to: the sun-forged Deliverer, Amphoreus' golden son, the man touched by every prophecy that Mydei had spent a lifetime refusing.

And yet.

There was softness in his eyes, still. Residue from their exchange. It lingered like warmth after fire, too faint to accuse and too certain to ignore. He looked at Mydei like that, sometimes. As if they shared a language no one else could quite translate.

Mydei watched him speak to the civilians, that bright smile still visible.

But he had seen the other moments, too.

Moments when the name was spoken—*Deliverer*—with reverence or desperation or awe, and the smile slipped. Just slightly. Like a blade sheathed too fast, catching on the leather.

Mydei had noticed.

He had said nothing.

They had set aside the southern courtyard for him.

Stone underfoot, high walls that cast hard shadows, and little enough greenery to distract the senses. It was one of the few places in Okhema that didn’t smell like incense or politics. Here, the air was dry, plain. The kind that bit at the lungs the longer one stood still.

Mydei never stood still for long.

As expected of the son of Gorgo, he kept his body like a shield—meant to be honed, never softened. Kremnos did not separate form from duty. A weak body invited a weak will. And a weak will died on its feet.

He moved through his forms with a practiced precision. Strike. Breathe. Repeat.

Stripped to the waist, his skin was slick with sweat, the lean strength of him marked by old campaign scars and the quiet strain of ritual control. The gauntlets sat folded beside the nearest column, polished, waiting. Each motion he made echoed faintly off the walls, like a silent chorus nodding in time.

He did not expect interruption.

Okheman courtiers were fond of wandering into places uninvited. But they rarely lingered when the air held this kind of heat.

Still, he heard the steps before he saw the shape.

And then—stillness.

A respectful distance. The kind that suggested either discipline or care. Possibly both.

He didn’t turn until the silence held long enough to prove it wasn’t an accident.

Phainon stood at the edge of the stones, sunlight tracing gold through his hair like it had been placed there on purpose. His arms were folded loosely. His gaze was direct.

“Training alone again?” Phainon asked, voice as composed as the rest of him. “You’ll make the rest of us look idle.”

Mydei reached for a cloth, wiped the sweat from his brow with slow efficiency. “Then work harder.”

Phainon only smiled, as if he’d expected no less.

There was something else in his expression, though. He was watching. Not just the sweat, not just the form—but him. Entirely. Like a man studying the last line of a forgotten script.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon said.

The name landed lightly, but the weight of it lingered.

Mydei turned, the cloth paused in his hand. He didn’t flinch—he never did—but he looked away a beat too soon, gaze sliding to the courtyard’s far edge as though assessing a fault in the stonework.

“You didn’t come here just to say my name,” he said.

“No,” Phainon admitted. “I came to ask if you’d spar.”

The request was direct. Unusual, but not unwelcome.

Mydei considered him. Then walked to the rack, tugging free two training swords—wooden, heavy enough to hurt but not severely harm.

He tossed one toward Phainon without ceremony. The man caught it easily.

“I usually fight with gauntlets,” Mydei said, removing the leather from where it wrapped around his forearms, setting them down beside the others. “But I’m told Okheman pride bruises easily.”

Phainon’s eyes dropped, just for a moment, to Mydei’s bare palms. The look wasn’t long enough to call out. But Mydei saw it. The quick intake of detail. The hesitation just before he looked away.

He said nothing.

Instead, he stepped onto the center stone and shifted his stance, balanced.

“Try not to embarrass yourself too badly, Deliverer.”

Phainon raised his sword in reply, smile tempered but still bright.

“I’ll do my best not to weep.”

Their blades met on the second breath.

The clash of wood against wood rang clean through the courtyard.

Phainon moved with a kind of practiced elegance—smooth footwork, well-balanced, the form of a man who had trained among scholars who taught battle as philosophy. There was beauty in it, to be sure, but Mydei had never believed beauty won a fight.

He shifted with less grace, more weight. His stance lower, his movements tighter. The sword in his hands was used like a lever, not a brush. He didn’t dance with it—he used it to break open space. His grip was unusual, one hand always moving ahead of the other, pivoting from odd angles. It made his attacks unpredictable. And his defense brutal.

The style came from an old Kremnoan school—one not taught anymore, except in half-remembered forms and grave-marked names. Where swordplay was meant to be short, sharp, and finished before the gods had time to look down. No one in Okhema would have recognized it. But it was still in his blood. Still lived behind his joints.

He didn’t speak as they fought.

There was no room for language when body was language enough.

Phainon was good. Better than most.

But Mydei was inevitable.

He adapted as he moved, growing more efficient with each clash. He disliked the sword, that much was clear—its reach was too long, its rhythm too indulgent. He preferred closer weight, denser balance. Something that could split air from lung and still be light enough to hide in the palm. Something honest. A dagger, perhaps. A gauntlet’s edge.

Still, he made do.

By the fourth exchange, Phainon had stopped smiling.

By the sixth, he was sweating.

By the ninth, he was on his back.

It happened in a blur of motion—Mydei twisted under a swing, shifted his weight low, and slammed into Phainon’s centerline with enough force to knock him off balance. The sword went skittering. Mydei followed him down, not with cruelty, but momentum, landing a knee beside Phainon’s hip, the other foot planted firm.

He hovered there for a breath—sword tip at Phainon’s throat.

And smiled.

It was a rare expression. Not mocking or purposefully cruel. But triumphant, sharp-edged with exertion and faint pleasure at his victory.

Phainon did not move.

His cheeks were red—not flushed in anger, but the heat that came from closeness, from impact, from something he couldn’t quite name.

He looked up, lips parted as though he meant to speak, then didn’t.

Mydei tilted his head, considering him.

Then stood.

He extended a hand soon after.

Phainon stared at it for a second longer than necessary, then reached up and took it, his grip warm and grounding.

They stood in silence, both catching breath.

“That was…” Phainon finally began, brushing back his damp hair, “… incredible. I’ve never seen swordwork like that.”

“It isn’t meant to be seen,” Mydei said, tone even. “It’s meant to end fights.”

Phainon laughed, not mocking—genuine.

“What is it? Some Kremnoan method?”

Mydei didn’t answer right away. He was rubbing his wrist, glancing at the wooden sword with distant disapproval. “I prefer closer weight. Blade or no. Something with a better center. This range is… wasteful.”

Phainon’s brow furrowed slightly. His gaze didn’t leave Mydei’s hands.

“Like a dagger?” he asked, too quickly.

Mydei’s eyes flicked to his. Then he raised a brow.

Phainon held his own expression still for a beat, then chuckled, easy again. “Curiosity. That’s all. You’re not exactly an open scroll, Mydeimos.”

“Then stop trying to read me.”

“I never said I’d stop,” Phainon replied, voice soft, amused.

He bowed his head slightly. “Thank you for the duel.”

Mydei gave no answer. Just turned back toward the rack to return the sword. But he did not stop Phainon from following.

“Next time, try to keep up.”

He stared at the gift for a long time.

Long enough that the oil in the lamp began to hiss from the heat. Long enough that his tea, untouched, cooled into bitterness. His expression did not shift. But something in the room had changed. The air had narrowed. The corners felt closer.

A dagger.

Curved into a crescent, forged in the Kremnoan style—shorter reach, back-weighted, meant for the kind of grip he favored. The handle was leather-wrapped, but worn smooth along the points where his calluses would fall. The blade itself was patterned, faintly. Not decorative. Forged under uneven temperatures, wave-shaped layers folding through the steel. The kind of forging one learned not from books but trial. Fire and error. Hands burned open until they remembered.

He picked it up.

It fit.

Not in the vague, flattered way of a craftsman guessing. But in the way of someone who had studied how he moved. Who had remembered.

There was a note. Folded beneath the dagger’s cloth.

He hesitated before unfolding it—not out of sentiment, but precision. The handwriting was a mess. Written in Kremnoan. Or an attempt at it.

The letters were formed with effort, some reversed, others misshaped by the roundness of a foreign tongue trying to fit itself into a square-boned

language. But the meaning was intact.

I have seen the shape of your shadow.
You are not kept for a throne.
You are shaped to move through blood.
Beauty is what endures.
You endure.
Therefore, you are beautiful.

He read it once. Then again.

And still, his expression did not shift.

It was not courtship. That word had no meaning in Kremnos. There, men did not present flowers. They presented oaths. If you meant to stand beside someone, you brought them what they would need to kill or die well. The edge. The armor. A stone to sharpen against.

This dagger—this thing—it was not affection.

It was allegiance.

And that made it worse.

He placed it on the table. Stared at it, still. As if willing it to explain itself.

It was the fifth gift.

He had dismissed the others eventually. The honey, the carved stone, the woven knot of thread meant to bring strength. The fourth had been olivewood, polished into a hand-held idol of Nikador, shaped in such a way that the expression held fury and grief in equal measure. That had unsettled him.

But this?

This was almost ridiculous.

A dagger, tailored to the weight of his palm, after he had spoken of it only once. In passing. During a sparring bout that had ended in sweat and silence.

Phainon.

The name came unbidden.

Mydei folded the note once more. Set it aside. Looked again at the dagger.

It was too easy.

Phainon had been there, yes. He had listened. He had stared too long. He had faltered when Mydei pinned him. He had said Mydeimos with too much softness, as if the name might wound. But—

No.

Phainon could not have made this.

The note alone made that clear. The man's Kremnoan, when he attempted it, was passable in speech. But this script—it had the clumsy strength of someone trying to mean something without knowing how. The language had been *felt*, not learned. Phainon would have learned it.

And Phainon did not hide.

Whatever else he was, he walked in light. In full view of all who adored him. His fame did not permit secrets.

A blade in the night was not his style.

And yet.

Mydei stared again at the dagger in his grip. Turned it once in his hand.

This one struck differently.

He did not store it with the others.

Instead, he placed it carefully in the chest beneath his chambers. Alongside the few things he kept:

The dagger from his first campaign.

The cloth, frayed and stained, torn from a sleeve the day he and Phainon collapsed into the dirt—neither victorious.

The honey jar.

And now, this.

Steel curved to his name.

The assembly chamber was stifling with the weight of too many words.

Braziers burned slow and heady. The air shimmered faintly above them, thick with perfumed smoke, a disguise for the rot of politics underneath. Voices rose in curated sequence, each one more intent on being heard than on saying anything worth the effort.

Mydei sat in stillness. The seat assigned to him was high enough to honor his rank, low enough to keep him out of the central line of fire. This was by design.

He would be returning to Kremnos in weeks. Perhaps sooner. The negotiations were nearing their end. These final sessions were little more than posturing.

He endured it as he endured most things here: silently, spine straight, hands resting palm-down on his knees. He counted breath, not time.

A Eutharkene delegate was speaking now.

The man was smooth-faced and narrow-eyed, dressed in the layered folds of some western court. He wore rings on every finger, too many to be practical. His voice flowed, practiced and bright, but there was a flex to it—

an unspoken need to provoke, to remind the room that his people had traded more than they'd ever spilled in blood.

"…and of course, we must consider the long-term viability of cultural integration," the delegate said, smiling. "We have made space, of course, for our more traditional allies—though some would argue there's a limit to how much deference should be extended to warrior cults clinging to archaic gods. It's admirable, I suppose, in the way old ruins are admirable. But one doesn't rebuild from ruins. One builds forward."

A few chuckles followed. Not loud. Not kind.

Mydei did not move. His expression did not shift.

But the weight of the room had changed.

The man went on. "And the language—blunt as a cudgel. No nuance. No flexibility. Every phrase sharpened to offend. I'm told they only speak when there's a death to confirm."

He kept talking.

Mydei bore it. Not because it didn't sting, but because in Kremnos, one does not defend what should be self-evident. He was Gorgo's son. He had learned from childhood to listen as he bled, and speak only once he'd measured the shape of his silence.

A pause came. A breath of waiting.

Then—Phainon's voice.

It did not rise above the chamber. It didn't need to. It carried with the kind of clarity that required no force to be heard.

"I've stood beside a Kremnoan who held his ribs together with his belt," he said. "Watched him walk into a room full of enemies and win a debate before any of them realized they were losing."

The delegate blinked. The smile faltered.

Phainon remained seated. Calm and composed. But something had turned in his tone—something quieter than anger, heavier than amusement.

“If you think them backward,” he continued, “you’ve never met a man who speaks only when he’s already made up his mind to act. That kind of restraint isn’t old. It’s discipline.”

Silence followed.

A real one, for once.

The speaker made a sound—an awkward half-laugh, half-cough—but didn’t recover well. The conversation shifted after that. Toned down.

Phainon said nothing else.

Mydei didn’t look at him. Not then. But he felt the shift. Not in the room—in himself. The burn across his collar, the way breath caught slightly in his nose before exhaling again, slow and measured.

He didn’t need a champion. But Phainon had spoken anyway.

And somehow, that was worse.

The assembly eventually dissolved in scattered applause and murmurs, the kind that pretended at harmony. Mydei stood only long enough to be polite, then turned to leave. No use lingering—he had already endured more words than most men back home could stomach in a season.

Another week. Then another. Then he would return to Kremnos. The thought braced him.

He didn’t look for Phainon. He had learned not to. Not when the man had a way of catching sight of him anyway.

Still, he saw him in the distance. Phainon had been speaking with one of the delegates, gesturing with a diplomat’s ease. But when his gaze swept across the crowd and caught Mydei’s figure, it stopped. His face shifted. Brighter—not surprised, but familiar, as if Mydei were someone expected.

Mydei ignored it. Stepped forward, kept his pace.

He was nearly free of the hall when a hand caught him at the shoulder—firm. He stopped without looking.

“Mydeimos.”

The name wasn’t mangled. It was pronounced with care.

He turned. Not fully. “Deliverer.”

His tone was civil, but taut. He hadn’t asked for this. He hadn’t wanted it. Still, he held his ground.

Phainon let his hand fall and took a half-step back. “I wanted to speak with you. About earlier.”

Mydei stared at him. “You weren’t the one who insulted me.”

“No,” Phainon agreed. “But I still owe you an apology.”

“Why?”

That was said without aggression, but blunt. Mydei was not being kind—only honest. There was nothing about the exchange that required remorse from a bystander.

Phainon hesitated. “Because you’re a guest of this city. You’ve given it your name, your silence, your restraint. That should mean something.”

It was not the words that unsettled Mydei—it was how he said them. So carefully.

“And Aglaea?” Mydei asked, tone flatter now.

Phainon’s eyes dropped for a moment, something dimming behind them. “She’s addressed it. Thoroughly.”

That could mean many things. Mydei didn’t ask. Better not to.

He gave a single nod and turned again.

He'd barely made it three steps before he was stopped again.

A hand, not on his shoulder this time, but at his sleeve. A quicker movement. Less thought behind it. Mydei's teeth clicked together with faint irritation as he looked over his shoulder.

"What is it now?"

Phainon stood there, flushed again. His expression unreadable for a breath too long, eyes fixed—not at the ground or the sky, but at Mydei's face. Steady. Searching.

Then he blinked, as if remembering himself.

"…I was going to ask if I could walk with you."

Mydei blinked once. Harder than necessary.

"You think I need escorting?"

"No," Phainon said. "But I'd still like to."

It made no sense. Mydei had led entire flanks through siege and slaughter. He was forged for endurance, not company. To be offered an escort was… absurd.

He opened his mouth to reject it, but then shut it again.

Phainon wasn't mocking him, he wasn't the type. And he wasn't weak. He was simply standing there, as if the question were the most natural thing in the world. As if asking to walk beside him wasn't a favor or a statement—just something he wanted.

"…Fine."

The word left like a knife sheathed against his better judgment.

They walked through the stone avenues toward the guest housing, the sun burning a pale red above them. Phainon said nothing at first. He matched pace without comment, and didn’t try to fill the silence with false ease.

When he did speak, it was low.

“I don’t often get to talk to you like this.”

“That’s by design,” Mydei replied, dryly.

Phainon smiled at that. “And yet, here I am.”

They moved another stretch in silence.

Then, after a pause: “You carry yourself as if the world is always watching.”

Mydei’s gaze shifted toward him.

Phainon didn’t look away. “I think it is.”

He didn’t explain the words, didn’t soften them either. They were said without irony or expectation.

Mydei didn’t answer.

He only kept walking—steps steady, shoulders squared—and Phainon stayed beside him all the way to the gate.

Mydei said nothing when they reached the gate.

Phainon offered a slight incline of his head, something between farewell and consideration. Mydei did not return it. He only turned, stepping through the threshold alone.

Later, he would not thank him.

But he would remember the look in Phainon’s eyes when he spoke—clear, unwavering.

He had not defended him.

He had named him.

That night, Mydei stood longer than usual by the window. Arms crossed, weight still braced as if for combat. He told himself it was out of habit. Out of vigilance. The stance of a man trained never to be caught unaware.

He was not waiting.

The courtyard below remained still.

No gift came.

He tried not to feel disappointed.

He failed.

They met alone in the upper gallery, where the air smelled faintly of brass and stone dust. Mydei stood with arms crossed behind his back, gaze fixed on the city below. Okhema spread outward in clean lines and high domes, a city built to inspire awe more than affection. He never learned to like it, but he had learned to tolerate it. That was enough.

Aglaea arrived without fanfare. Her golden strings moved like threads caught in current, sensing the edges of the room before her footsteps followed. She did not ask if he saw her. He always did.

“You will leave in three days,” she said. Not a question.

“I will.”

“Okhema will not forget your presence,” she continued, walking until they stood nearly level. “Nor the discipline you taught it.”

He said nothing. Praise meant little unless it was earned in blood. And Aglaea did not flatter.

She turned her face toward him, the golden strings hovering outward like antennae. “I trust your hosts treated you with what passes for respect.”

“My hosts,” he said, “did not lack manners.”

“But others did.”

He did not confirm or deny it. The memory of that last assembly still pressed against his ribs, heavy as a bruise. He hadn’t spoken of it to anyone.

Aglaea turned her head to Mydei curiously, but not exactly. “It is not your custom to complain.”

“It is not yours either,” he replied.

That made her smile—barely.

“I have learned,” she said, “that the line between tolerance and insult is thinner than silk. You walk it well.”

“I was not sent here to feel comfortable.”

“No. You were sent to be seen.”

His eyes narrowed, faintly.

Aglaea’s head tilted as if studying him, though her strings remained still. “You carry your homeland in the way you breathe, Mydeimos. In the way you stand, the way you speak. That is a kind of power.”

He did not respond. There was nothing to say to something that was simply true.

She went on, voice steady, but there was a hum beneath it. “Some feared your presence. Others misunderstood it. One saw it.”

At that, he turned to her fully. “And which are you?”

“I am not one who underestimates a weapon.” She stepped closer, close enough that her strings brushed against the edge of his mantle. “But I am one who honors the hand that wields it.”

The silence stretched, not uncomfortable, but deliberate.

Then she said, “This city will not offer you fond farewells or weeping crowds. You would not want them.”

“No.”

“But you will not leave forgotten.”

She let that hang for a moment, then stepped back. “That is all.”

He nodded once. Formal. Finished.

She turned to go, and he let her.

Only when she reached the archway did she pause.

“Walk with care in these last days, Mydeimos. You are still being watched.”

She left.

He stood alone again—watching and now wondering what, exactly, she meant.

The door closed behind him with a muted thud. Mydei pressed the latch into place out of habit, not caution. The room smelled faintly of oil and parchment—quiet signs of departure. He had begun the slow task of sorting what would return to Kremnos with him, what would be left behind, what should be burned.

Three days remained.

A note lay half-finished on his desk, a formal reply to a diplomatic overture he cared little for. He didn’t look at it. His eyes were drawn instead to the

box that hadn’t been there before.

Small. Wooden. Pale grain. It sat at the center of his writing desk with the stillness of something waiting. No seal. No ribbon. No markings at all.

He didn’t tense. He didn’t smile either. These gifts had become common now. He had stopped expecting them and yet had stopped being surprised. He thought it might be a final gesture—something symbolic. A keepsake, perhaps. Something clever or poetic in that strange way his admirer favored.

He crossed the room without hesitation.

The lid lifted easily under his fingers.

And then he stopped.

There was no thought, no sound. Only the pressure in his chest—the kind that pressed against bone, demanding to be let through.

A ring.

Gold-veined, weighty with age. Its surface had dulled in places, worn smooth by skin and time. The dark stone set at its center still gleamed, despite everything, and atop it—a carving, delicate and unyielding.

A descending spear.

Strife’s mark.

His mother’s.

The breath fled him. Not stolen. Not startled away. It simply left, forgotten, as if his body had no need of it. As if the rules of flesh no longer applied.

He stared.

His mother had worn that ring always—at court, at training, even on the day she had died.

He had not spoken of that day since it happened. Not to tutors, not to kin, not even to the few he had once called brothers-in-arms. The memory had become ritual. Repetition. She was gone. The ring was lost. It had disappeared with her in the Sea of Souls, and no one—not priest, not general, not god—had seen it since.

He remembered the last time he'd touched it.

He had been a boy then. Her hands had been cold, already stilled. The blood on the ring had dried like rust. He'd tried to pry it off her finger, not to keep it, but to save it. But she had already gone, and the ring had not come free.

He had not found it again.

Until now.

It was not possible. It was not something that should have been returned to him. No servant would have known its meaning. No artisan could have replicated the wear, the weight, the faded warmth of it. Hell, no diver could've found it as well, not even the Gods dare to venture there. This was not a symbol.

It was hers.

He reached for it.

The cool of the metal met his palm with a terrible familiarity.

He didn't weep.

Kremnoans did not weep.

But he stood still for a long time, hand wrapped around something heavier than gold, heavier than the past.

A gift.

Not romantic. Not clever.

This had cost something. Time. Pain. Memory. Perhaps more.

He didn’t ask how it had come to him. He would not name the sea it had been lost to. He would not name the man who had found it.

But his chest ached in a way it never did before.

He sat down.

Only then did he breathe again. Ragged. Dry.

He stared at the ring in his palm, then shut the lid of the box and set it beside the rest of his packed belongings.

He would not wear it yet.

But he would carry it.

Two days passed. One remained. Tomorrow, he would leave Okhema.

The city had begun to turn its gaze elsewhere—toward spring festivals, toward the next speaker’s arrival, toward whatever new foreign oddity might grace its streets. Mydei moved through it unseen, as he preferred. His steps were purposeful, his mind set on the return. Kremnos would expect not just a prince but a weapon honed anew. He would deliver.

And yet.

And yet.

His thoughts returned to the ring too often. Too easily. Its weight had never left him. He had not worn it, only touched it once more—briefly. Enough to know it was real. Enough to make him question the world again.

He did not think of his mother. He did not need to. The ring bore the mark of Strife, the same way it had looked on her hand the last day he saw her alive.

She had died not at sea but by a man who once called himself king.

The Sea of Souls had taken her afterward. That cursed place did not return what it swallowed—not to mortals, not to demigods, not even to gods.

And yet it had returned this.

Mydei had not spoken of it. Not to Aglaea. Not to Phainon. Not even in his own mind aloud. But the question burned now. Who?

He was passing through one of the inner markets when he overheard them. Two guards. Young. Leaning lazily against a column, sharing gossip in low tones.

“—swear it happened. Four days ago. Said he walked straight out the tide. Madman. Laughing like he knew something we didn’t. Salt in his lashes. Eyes wide. Said he found a ghost and brought it home.”

Mydei slowed. Only a step. But his heel echoed against the marble tile.

He hadn’t meant to stop. He never meant to draw attention, but one of the men turned slightly. Mydei’s stare shut him up fast.

A ghost and brought it home.

He was about to speak—he, who rarely engaged with anyone not required to speak with him. He opened his mouth, the question forming—

Then someone else chuckled and said, “You know, that reminds me. Didn’t Phainon come back that day, too? Drenched. To the collar. Not a scratch on him. Just grinning. Said it was ‘personal leave.’ Right.”

They laughed.

Mydei did not.

He remembered. A week past, Phainon had vanished. No word. No summons. Just gone. For days.

And then, just as suddenly, he had returned. Whole. Soaked. Unapologetic.

That smile—yes. It had not been soft. It had not been kind.

It had been victorious.

Mydei stood in the hall, and for a breathless moment, he felt nothing.

Then everything.

Of course. Of course it was him. Who else had the gall to court a prince not through flattery, not through softness, but through reverence? Through quiet endurance? Through gifts that spoke in the old tongue of Kremnos—honey and blades and blood-won relics?

It would’ve taken madness to find it. Or devotion. Or both. And there was only one man in Okhema mad enough to fight ten nights without sleep. Who once said nothing when the crown of Amphoreus was offered to him, only nodded like it was just another weight to carry.

Phainon.

The Deliverer.

Of course.

Hours had passed since the realization. He hadn’t eaten. Hadn’t spoken. Hadn’t trained. At some point, he’d found himself standing in the garden square of the embassy, blankly eyeing a stone basin full of fish. Why they were there, he didn’t know. He’d only registered that he was still in Okhema, it was his final day, and he had nothing.

He—Mydeimos, son of war, scion of Kremnos, the last blood-born contender for the Strife coreflame—was scrambling for a gift. A proper one.

He’d tried.

He’d considered forging a shortblade, something light and curved, something that matched Phainon’s reach and form. He’d nearly done it, too—until he realized that Phainon didn’t need another weapon. He already wielded people and rooms with ease.

Then there were the poems.

To the one who knew what it meant to give this back to me—
You are no longer a mystery.
You are a man I would name beside me in the war songs.
You are the only one who learned how to speak without words.

He’d burned the page immediately.

Kremnoans didn’t write poems unless someone had died or someone had won a war. This was neither. And besides, words weren’t enough. Not for that ring. Not for what it meant.

Then, finally, the thought came to him.

He returned to his quarters, lit the lamps for the last time, and began the work.

A rare courtship tradition. Ancient, even by Kremnoan standards. A laurel crown—charred at the edges in ritual flame and quenched in saltwater.

The burned laurel was customarily given at the funeral pyre of warriors whose deaths were honorable, deaths that struck songs into the hearts of their kin. But if one lived long enough—if one was respected enough—to be given a laurel while still breathing, it meant something else entirely.

It meant: I see in you what others will never understand. I name you as one who could have stood among the fallen, and yet you are here. You are worthy of grief, of fire, of remembrance—before your end has come.

You are worthy now.

It was not soft. It was not romantic in the way Okheman customs might call it. But to a Kremnoan, this was a kind of devotion deeper than softness.

This was the recognition of someone who could stand beside you on the battlefield and still live in your mind afterward.

He shaped the crown himself. Selected each laurel leaf from the grove below the embassy. Twisted them into place with scorched bronze wire. Held it to the flame just long enough to blacken the edges. Let the saltwater steam when he quenched it.

Then he set it down and stared at it.

A gift for a man who had named him not with titles or songs, but with a single gaze, a single offering, and the silence of a shared tongue.

Tomorrow, he would leave. Tonight, he would wait.

He spotted him by the archives—a rare lull, alone for once.

Phainon had that look about him. The one he wore after diplomatic talks he hadn’t asked for but had endured with grace nonetheless: hands loosely clasped behind his back, expression at half-mast, as if someone had just asked him to explain taxes in verse. Tired, but gracious. Doomed, but charming about it.

Then he turned—and saw Mydei.

And all of it fell away. That mask of tolerance, the half-buried sigh—gone. His spine straightened with unconscious precision. The corner of his mouth twitched upward, ready to greet with something warm and practiced.

But Mydei did not stop to speak.

He closed the distance in five quiet strides, reached out, and took him by the wrist.

It was not forceful.

It was also not optional.

Phainon stared down at the fingers curled around his arm like he'd just been seized by a storm lo he hadn't seen coming. There was a pause—longer than either of them might admit—where Phainon simply looked at the place they were touching. Then up at Mydei's face.

Mydei, for his part, didn't even break stride.

He did not explain himself. He did not check if Phainon followed. He just shifted his grip slightly—up, from wrist to elbow, steadier—and started walking.

Dragging was too crude a word. It implied resistance. There was none.

"Ah," Phainon said faintly, not so much in protest as in… data collection. "So this is happening."

Another step.

Phainon's brows rose. "Should I be—Mydei, am I being kidnapped?"

Still no answer.

Phainon turned his head slightly, casting a baffled glance over his shoulder, as if someone might explain this to him. No one did.

He looked forward again.

Mydei hadn't so much as flinched. His grip was careful. Firm, yes, but never bruising. As though he had contemplated exactly how much force a man like Phainon would allow before it became mockery. As though he'd done this before. As though he'd thought about it.

That realization caught Phainon like a blow—not to the chest, but somewhere stranger. More vulnerable.

His mouth opened again, then closed. For once in his gilded, tireless life, words did not come.

He let himself be taken.

Not because he couldn’t stop him. But because, gods help him, he didn’t want to.

He led him up stone steps worn smooth with time. Past the upper terraces, past the colonnades draped in silks, until Okhema gave way to wind and elevation. A rooftop—not one of grandeur, not one of ceremony. It was quiet here. Bare, save for a wide stretch of open air, and the long view of the holy city below.

Phainon, for once, said nothing on the climb.

But when they reached the top, he stood still a moment. Turned slowly in place, taking in the expanse, the waning light that never truly left this city. And then, with that same careful courtesy he used at assemblies, he angled his head toward Mydei, expression gentled.

“Mydei,” he said, voice soft with apology, “if I’m being brought somewhere to be executed, I think you’ve chosen a lovely view.”

Mydei only looked at him.

Phainon cleared his throat. “Or perhaps a duel. I do still owe you a rematch.”

Still nothing.

So Phainon tried again. “Or you’ve brought me here to finally explain why you’ve been looking at me like I’m a siege to be mapped and not a man. Which, frankly, would be a relief.”

Mydei exhaled—not a laugh, not quite, but something in his chest gave. He shook his head once, distractedly, as if Phainon had asked a foolish question in a foreign tongue.

“I should’ve known,” he said under his breath. “It was obvious.”

Phainon blinked. “I’m sorry?”

But Mydei had already turned away, crouching by a low column where something had been left behind—wrapped in cloth, dark and fire-touched at the edges.

When he stood again, it was in his hands.

“I considered forging a blade,” he said without preamble. “Or writing. I began both. Finished neither.”

He stepped closer. Close enough for the breeze to press the edges of his cloak against Phainon’s legs. The object in his hand was now unwrapped: blackened laurel leaves, still faintly ash-scented, their edges sealed and quenched in salt.

“You recognize this?” he asked.

Phainon stared.

It took him longer than he’d admit to answer. “I… think so,” he said slowly. “But that—Mydei, you can’t—”

“I can.”

“You shouldn’t.”

“And yet,” Mydei murmured.

Before Phainon could protest again, Mydei stepped close—so close Phainon felt the warmth of him, the impossibly steady weight of a hand that had fought ten days against his own. And then, without warning or request, Mydei lifted the crown of charred laurels and placed it on his head.

Phainon didn’t move.

Didn’t breathe.

For the space of several heartbeats, he simply stood there, frozen in the way a man does when an old myth becomes real and chooses him.

Then, in a voice uneven for the first time all week, he whispered, “You’re the heir to a godless throne. You can’t crown me.”

Mydei tilted his head, unreadable. “I’m not crowning you.”

“You placed it like—”

“This is a gift.”

“It’s—” Phainon stopped. His voice had climbed half a register. He closed his eyes briefly. “This is too much.”

Mydei regarded him for a moment. Then, with a softness that almost passed for indulgence, said, “Would you rather I forged a sword?”

Phainon opened his mouth to argue, realized too late there was no good answer, and closed it again.

A beat passed. Then Mydei said, simply, “You dove into the Sea of Souls.”

Phainon went still.

He glanced sideways—anywhere but Mydei’s eyes. “I don’t know what you mean.”

“You returned drenched.”

“That happens, in storms. Or fountains.”

Mydei folded his arms. “You were missing for a week.”

“I took personal leave.”

“No wounds.”

“I heal fast.”

“You smelled like salt and ghosts.”

“I—” Phainon stopped. Then, quieter, “…should get some rest. You’re leaving tomorrow.”

A silence bloomed between them, not tense, not cold—just full. Full of the weight of everything that hadn’t been said.

Mydei watched him a moment longer.

Then thought, *That man does not lie well.*

Not to him. Not anymore.

Mydei watched him, long enough for Phainon to start shifting like he might excuse himself.

Then, at last, Mydei sighed.

“I accept your cowardice.”

Phainon blinked. “I’m sorry?”

“It is not uncommon,” Mydei added, almost indulgently, “for men to fear the things they’ve won.”

Phainon’s mouth parted, clearly to protest—but something in Mydei’s face made him pause.

So Phainon exhaled. Then stepped forward, close enough that their shadows nearly overlapped. He looked at Mydei like he might still argue, and then didn’t.

Instead, he reached out—took Mydei’s hand with a quiet reverence—and turned it palm-up.

“I don’t know your tongue,” he said, voice low, “but if you have no word for love, then let this suffice.”

He bent, pressed a kiss to the center of Mydei’s calloused palm—warm and deliberate, a vow disguised as a gesture—and then looked up again, eyes

bright with something far more dangerous than affection.

“I hope Kremnos sends someone to fetch you back,” he murmured, “because Okhema may not want to let you go.”

Mydei stared at him a moment, and then—rare as fresh blood on snow—smiled.

It was not grand. It was not noble. It was almost crooked, like it hadn’t been worn in years.

“When you visit,” he said, “you should see the Kremnoan library first.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow. “Before what?”

Mydei stepped past him then, toward the stairs. And without looking back, replied:

“Before I show you what that return truly cost.”

It wasn’t a threat. Not quite. Not when his voice held such warmth.

At the top of the stairs, he paused.

“You were right,” he said. “I should rest. I leave tomorrow.”

He turned slightly, enough to meet Phainon’s gaze.

“Until next time,” he said, and the old title hovered on his tongue, waiting to be summoned.

But it never came.

“Phainon.”

Then he was gone, descending into the hush of the city below.

And Phainon—drenched in titles, yet suddenly just a man—stood alone on the rooftop, hand still tingling from where it had been held. His composure

did not follow him into the silence.

Not undone.

But very, very close.

End Notes

Oof hope the pacing wasn’t too rushed. I’m probably gonna slow down on the one shots to finish up some of my multi chaptered fics (Unless I make another sports au one😭) but feel free to drop any recs in the comments.

Thank you for reading guys😍

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!